

AI felt faster. The stopwatch said it barely was.

Stanford-led researchers timed 2,691 people on quick tasks, with and without AI. What people expected and what happened were far apart.

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TIME PEOPLE EXPECTED AI TO SAVE ON A QUICK TASK

55.7 sec

It actually saved 7.5 seconds. Three preregistered studies, all on tasks that take under five minutes.

01 You know your own speed

People guessed they would need 99 seconds alone. They took 93.7. Their guess with AI was 43.3 seconds. It took 86.2, nearly double.

The easiest tasks, timed

BY HAND

60.2 seconds on
average.

WITH AI

70.2 seconds.
Writing the
prompt took
longer than
reading the
answer.

02 You use AI more than you think

Asked ahead, people said they would use AI on 33% of tasks. They used it on 47%. On the easiest tasks, 20% said yes and 38% did.

03 Using it makes you reach for it again

After two tasks with AI, people chose it for 44.5% of the next ones. After two tasks done alone, 27.7%.

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People will use AI if they believe it to be faster.

YU ET AL., STANFORD, ARXIV, 2026

What it does not mean: that AI is slow on big jobs. Every task in these studies took under five minutes.

DO THIS TODAY

Time one small task both ways

Pick one small task you now hand to AI. Do it once by hand and once with AI, and time both. Keep the faster habit.

One idea, decoded, every week

Plain English, a named source, and one thing
to do with it.

Decoding AI

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